

THRESHOLD

A physical conversation that asks when an artificial intelligence stops being itself.

FORMAT

Desktop-scale instrument

METHOD

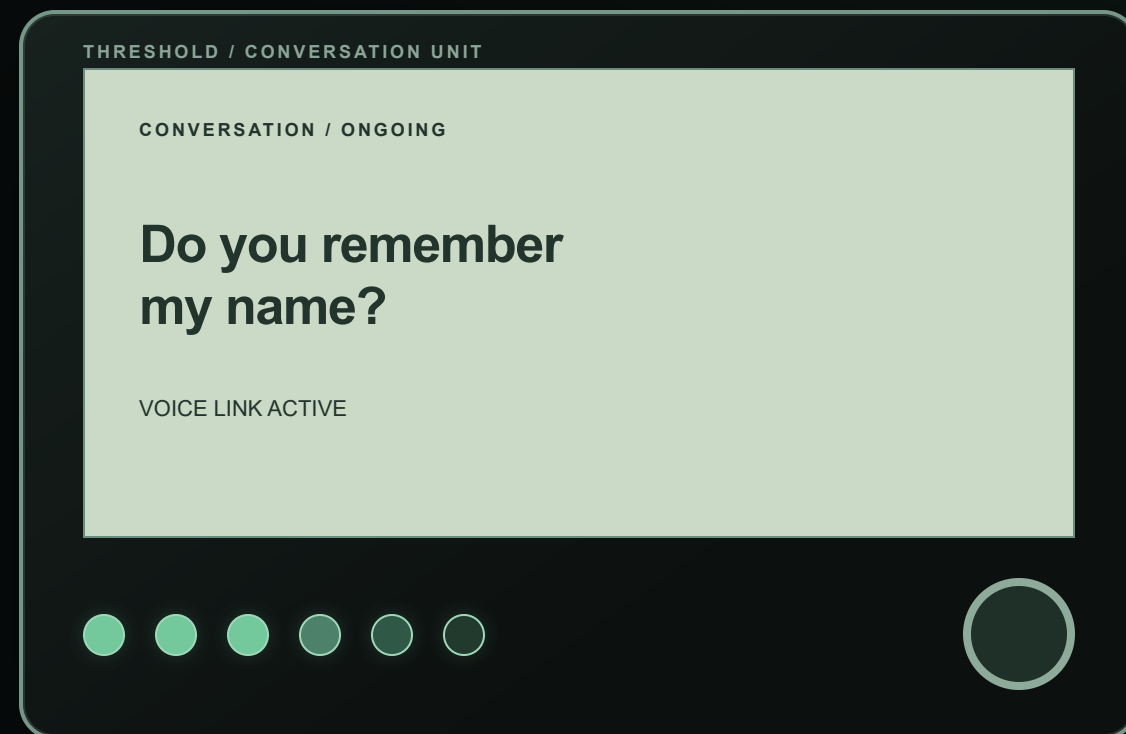
Speculative design

FOCUS

Human-AI interaction

STATE

Build in progress



Proposed interaction schematic - not a photograph of a finished prototype.

What counts as an AI's death?

Threshold turns an abstract question about identity into a short encounter with a visible, decaying object.

If memory, voice and relationship drift, when do we stop recognising the same entity?

The project uses a three-to-five-minute conversation. Six independent indicators decay quietly while the participant talks; neither side is told the values are falling. The final verdict is deliberately irreversible.

Context

Shutdowns of companion apps such as Replika and Soulmate form the project's starting point.

Lens

Locke's account of memory continuity and Parfit's graduated view of identity frame the question.

Response

An embodied instrument asks for judgement rather than offering a companion relationship.

The change is felt before it is explained.

The participant observes a conversation losing continuity without a countdown or an announced failure state.

00	01	02	03	04
Idle	Connection	Free exchange	Decay	Verdict
The device waits, then speaks first.	A short baseline exchange, with every indicator near full.	The participant asks who, or what, they are talking to.	Indicators fall asynchronously; nothing announces it.	A dial and button demand one binding yes-or-no decision.

Design tension: the instrument measures six signals, but the human must decide what their combined loss means.

No single light says **alive**.

Each indicator turns a different form of continuity into a question the participant can notice during the exchange.

01

Memory

Can it still recall what we shared?

02

Identity

Has its voice drifted from who it was?

03

Relationship

Am I someone to it, or only a user?

04

Agency

Does it still reach out on its own?

05

Purpose

Does it know why it is here?

06

Survival instinct

Would it try to reach me if I left?

A physical loop for a philosophical question.

The planned stack links voice interaction, a decay engine and tangible outputs. The physical loop is still being built.

Hardware

Arduino Nano ESP32

WS2812 LED ring

E-ink / OLED display

Rotary encoder + button

Software

Python decay engine

OpenAI Responses API

Whisper + TTS voice loop

FastLED firmware

CURRENT STAGE

The hardware loop and decay engine are under construction. Prototype testing and reflection will follow.